Expanded JAPAC WhatsApp & Viber Scam Catalogue

Japan + Asia-Pacific • Broad documentation set for research, awareness & hackathon ideation • October 2026

Scope. This is intentionally broader than a “top scams” list. It catalogs major scam families, smaller variants, and scam mechanics that can be delivered through WhatsApp, Viber, or another messaging service. A scam family may occur through other channels too; inclusion here means the pattern is relevant to messaging-app abuse or has been documented through messaging platforms. JAPAC is heterogeneous, so the catalogue should not be read as a prevalence ranking.

A. Employment, task & income scams

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
1	Fake job / recruitment	Unexpected recruiter offers unusually high pay, flexible remote work, or overseas employment; conversation moves to WhatsApp/Viber and eventually asks for money or identity documents.	Upfront fee; guaranteed job; pressure; unverifiable recruiter.
2	Task / optimization scam	Victim completes likes, reviews, orders, app optimization or similar tasks. Small commissions may appear first; deposits then escalate.	Pay-to-earn; escalating deposits; fake balance/earnings.
3	E-commerce assistant scam	Victim is told to place or 'complete' online orders to generate commissions. More expensive orders require the victim's own funds.	Refund/commission promise; top-up requirement.
4	Survey-for-money scam	Simple surveys allegedly pay commissions, then 'advanced' surveys require deposits or transfers.	Payment needed to unlock surveys/earnings.
5	Affiliate marketing scam	Victim is told to promote products or generate sales, often through another messaging contact, with reimbursement/commission promised after payment.	Repeated small purchases progressing to large ones.
6	Fake freelance / gig scam	Scammer offers a freelance project, asks for registration, equipment, training, verification, or platform fees, then disappears or harvests identity data.	Payment before work; fake contract; unnecessary sensitive documents.
7	Work-from-home crypto top-up scam	Recruiter routes victim to a crypto account; victim is paid a small amount and told to top up to unlock higher-paying tasks.	Crypto wallet requirement; withdrawal blocked.

B. Investment & financial-growth scams

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
8	Fake investment group	Victim is added to a WhatsApp/Viber group filled with fake experts and fake member testimonials.	Many accounts praising the same platform; unsolicited group invite.
9	Fake trading platform/app	Scammer directs victim to a fraudulent website or app that displays fabricated profits.	Profit shown but withdrawal impossible; extra fees/taxes.
10	Pig-butchering / relationship investment	Trust or romance is built first; later the scammer introduces crypto, forex, stocks, or another investment.	Rapid intimacy + financial opportunity.
11	Fake stock/IPO opportunity	Scammer impersonates an analyst, broker, or investment company and offers supposedly exclusive shares or pre-IPO access.	Guaranteed/inside opportunity; payment to personal accounts.
12	Celebrity/public-figure investment impersonation	Fake account or AI-generated persona promotes an investment or financial opportunity.	Celebrity endorsement that cannot be independently verified.
13	Government/royalty investment impersonation	Scammer poses as a senior official, royal, or official representative and asks for transfers or participation in an opportunity.	Unusual investment request; fake meeting/NDA.
14	Recovery / refund scam	After a victim has already lost money, a second scammer claims they can recover it for a fee.	Claims access to authorities, lawyers, hackers or recovery funds.
15	Money-mule recruitment	Victim is recruited to receive, transfer, withdraw, or convert money/crypto on someone else's behalf.	Commission for moving funds; use of personal bank/wallet.
16	Fake loan / advance-fee loan	Fast loan with minimal checks; victim pays processing, insurance, release, or verification fees first.	Upfront payment before loan disbursement.

C. Phishing, account takeover & identity theft

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
17	WhatsApp verification-code takeover	Scammer triggers an OTP and persuades the victim to forward it, often claiming it was sent accidentally.	Unexpected OTP request.
18	Compromised-contact impersonation	After an account is taken over, the scammer messages the victim's contacts and asks for emergency money.	Known contact + unusual request; new payment destination.
19	Fake customer support	Scammer impersonates WhatsApp, Viber, a bank, e-wallet, courier, marketplace, or platform support team.	Support arrives unsolicited; asks for OTP/password.
20	Account suspension / verification phishing	Victim is told their account will be suspended unless they verify identity through a link.	Urgency + login link.

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
21	Government-ID phishing	Scammer poses as a national ID agency or government service and requests ID details, screen sharing, app deletion, or security changes.	Government branding + remote-control instructions.
22	SIM / number-change social engineering	Scammer uses personal details to persuade a carrier or victim to facilitate account recovery or number transfer.	Unexpected SIM/account-change notification.
23	QR-code phishing	A QR code is presented as a payment, refund, verification, or login step and leads to a malicious page or payment destination.	QR code from unsolicited contact.
24	Malicious APK/app link	Victim is told to install an app for delivery, employment, banking, investment, or account verification.	APK outside official store; requests for excessive permissions.
25	Screen-sharing / remote-control scam	Victim is instructed to share their screen or install remote-support software to 'fix' an account.	Request to disable security or reveal OTPs.

D. Delivery, shopping & payment scams

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
26	Parcel / courier phishing	Fake delivery notice says a parcel failed, needs address confirmation, or requires a small payment.	Unexpected package + link + card/OTP request.
27	Customs / import-fee scam	Victim is told an overseas parcel is held by customs and requires urgent payment.	Unverified customs contact; payment link.
28	Fake buyer / seller scam	Scammer pretends to buy or sell an item and sends fake payment confirmation or a malicious courier/payment link.	Overpayment; fake receipt; pressure to ship.
29	Fake refund scam	Scammer says a payment/refund failed and asks for card details, login credentials, or a transfer to 'receive' money.	Refund requires payment or full banking credentials.
30	Marketplace task / order scam	Victim is recruited to process marketplace orders, pay first, and supposedly receive reimbursement plus commission.	Repeated prepayment.
31	Gift card / voucher scam	Scammer claims payment must be made through gift cards or vouchers and requests codes/photos.	Irreversible payment method.
32	QR payment redirection	Victim is told a QR code is for a legitimate recipient, refund, donation, or booking but it directs funds elsewhere.	Recipient name mismatch.
33	Fake rewards / loyalty-points phishing	Message claims points are expiring and directs victim to redeem them through a link.	Urgent expiry + credential/payment page.

E. Romance, social & exploitation scams

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
34	Romance scam	Scammer builds emotional attachment, then asks for money, financial help, account access, or transfers.	Love-bombing; repeated emergencies; no real-world verification.
35	Wrong-number / accidental-message scam	Conversation begins with an apparently mistaken message and gradually becomes friendship, romance, or investment fraud.	Persistent stranger despite wrong number.
36	Sextortion	Scammer obtains intimate images/video and threatens to distribute them unless paid.	Threats to contacts; escalating payments.
37	Fake identity / catfishing	Stolen photos, names, employment histories, or identities are used to build credibility and extract money/data.	Inconsistent identity; refuses verification.
38	Friend/family emergency impersonation	Scammer claims to be a child, parent, partner, or friend using a new number/account and asks for urgent money.	New number + emergency + urgency.
39	Celebrity/fan scam	Fake celebrity, manager, or fan-club representative contacts victim and asks for fees, gifts, donations, or investment.	Private 'exclusive' access; payment request.
40	Blackmail / threat scam	Scammer threatens reputational, legal, employment, or personal consequences unless money or information is provided.	Threats + deadline.

F. Government, institutional & authority impersonation

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
41	Police / law-enforcement impersonation	Victim is told they are implicated in a crime, investigation, fine, or warrant and must pay or provide documents.	Threat of arrest; secrecy; immediate payment.
42	Tax / revenue authority impersonation	Fake tax notice requests payment, account verification, or identity information.	Tax deadline + payment link.
43	Immigration / visa scam	Fake immigration official or agent offers visa processing, residency, or work authorization for an upfront fee.	Guaranteed approval; unofficial payment.

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
44	Embassy / consular impersonation	Scammer poses as an embassy/consulate representative and requests emergency payment or documents.	Unusual emergency payment request.
45	National ID / civil registry impersonation	Scammer claims an ID is expiring, invalid, or needs updating through a link.	False deadline; identity-document request.
46	Social insurance / pension impersonation	Fake agency account asks members/pensioners to update information or provide financial details.	Unapproved messaging account.
47	Government grant / subsidy scam	Victim is told they qualify for aid, subsidy, refund, or benefit but must pay a release/processing fee.	Fee to receive supposed government money.

G. Travel, education & event scams

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
48	Airline / travel booking scam	Fake booking agent or airline support sends a payment/refund link.	Urgent rebooking; payment outside official channel.
49	Hotel / accommodation scam	Fake hotel representative requests deposit or payment through a messaging app.	Payment to personal account; booking not independently visible.
50	Study-abroad / scholarship scam	Fake school, scholarship, exchange, or education representative asks for application or placement fees.	Guaranteed scholarship/placement.
51	Youth exchange / course impersonation	Compromised account impersonates a student and asks parents to pay for a supposed exchange/course.	Parent contacted from child's account; QR payment.
52	Event / concert ticket scam	Scammer sells fake tickets or requests deposits through chat.	Below-market price; refusal to use protected marketplace.

H. Charity, crisis & unexpected-money scams

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
53	Fake charity / donation scam	Scammer uses a disaster, conflict, illness, or humanitarian cause to request donations.	Urgent emotional appeal; personal payment account.
54	Disaster-relief scam	Fake fundraiser appears after an earthquake, typhoon, flood, fire, or other crisis.	Unverified organization; crypto or personal account.
55	Lottery / prize scam	Victim is told they won a prize and must pay taxes, customs, or processing fees first.	Prize you never entered; upfront fee.
56	Inheritance scam	Scammer claims victim is an heir to an estate and requests legal/release fees.	Unexpected inheritance + advance payment.
57	Overpayment / mistaken-transfer scam	Scammer claims to have accidentally transferred too much money and asks the victim to return funds before the original transaction is securely verified.	Urgent refund; fake payment evidence.

I. Business & organizational fraud

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
58	CEO / senior-executive impersonation	Fake CEO/supervisor contacts an employee through WhatsApp and requests a confidential transfer or sensitive information.	Confidentiality demand; bypassing normal approval.
59	Supplier / invoice redirection	Scammer impersonates a vendor and asks a business to change bank details for future payments.	New bank account; urgent change.
60	Fake confidential project	Employee is told to work on a secret project and sign an NDA, then transfer funds or disclose company data.	Isolation from colleagues; unusual secrecy.
61	Fake investor / partner	Scammer poses as a prospective investor, business partner, or client and requests fees, documents, or access.	Unverifiable company; advance payment.
62	Executive video/deepfake impersonation	Messaging contact leads to a video call where a supposed executive, investor, or official is digitally manipulated or impersonated.	Unusual meeting request + payment instruction.

J. Data harvesting & device compromise

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
63	Personal-data harvesting	Scammer builds a profile using ID, address, employment, family, banking, or account information collected through chat.	Requests for unrelated personal details.
64	Credential harvesting	Fake login/verification page captures email, password, banking or platform credentials.	Lookalike domain; login via unsolicited link.
65	Contact-list harvesting	Victim is encouraged to sync contacts, install an app, or provide access that enables further targeting.	Unnecessary contact permission.

#	Pattern	How it works	Key warning signals
66	Malware delivery through documents	Scammer sends an apparently legitimate file, form, invoice, resume, or application intended to trigger malicious software.	Unexpected attachment; macro/executable/archive.
67	AI/deepfake identity fraud	Scammer uses AI-generated faces, voices, altered video, or synthetic profiles to appear credible.	Impossible/odd identity details; pressure prevents independent verification.

Cross-cutting scam mechanics

Trust-building: Fake testimonials, group members, professional branding, stolen identities, small initial payments, or romantic attention.

Urgency: Deadlines, expiring parcels/points, account suspension, limited job slots, emergencies, or threats.

Isolation: Requests to keep an opportunity secret, avoid colleagues/family, or use a private chat.

Escalation: Small payment → larger payment → 'unlock' fee → tax/verification fee → recovery fee.

Authority: Use of banks, police, government logos, CEOs, celebrities, schools, couriers, or regulators.

Payment substitution: Requests to use crypto, gift cards, QR codes, personal accounts, cash handovers, or other hard-to-reverse methods.

Credential theft: OTP, password, PIN, card number, banking login, recovery code, ID document, or screen-sharing request.

Platform migration: Victim starts on social media, dating app, job portal, or SMS and is moved to WhatsApp/Viber/another private channel.

Synthetic identity: Stolen profile photos, fabricated employment histories, AI-generated images/voices, or digitally manipulated video.

JAPAC-specific documented examples

• Singapore (2026): WhatsApp investment-learning groups used fake mentors, fake profit screenshots and fraudulent investment sites/apps; police reported at least 48 cases and S$3.6 million in losses since May 2026.

• Singapore (2026): compromised WhatsApp accounts were used to impersonate contacts and request emergency loans; victims were first tricked into surrendering WhatsApp OTPs.

• Singapore (2026): WhatsApp messages impersonating SingPost claimed failed parcel delivery and redirected victims to phishing sites requesting banking/card information and OTPs.

• Singapore (2025): WhatsApp/Telegram job scams offered social-media and e-commerce boosting tasks, initially paying small commissions before requiring larger transfers.

• Singapore (2026): scammers impersonated company CEOs/supervisors on WhatsApp, sometimes using digitally manipulated video calls, and sought confidential information and company funds.

• Singapore (2026): compromised student WhatsApp accounts were used to impersonate students and ask parents to pay for supposed youth-exchange or AI-course places.

• Australia (2026): Scamwatch documented fake WhatsApp investment groups and recruitment scams that moved victims into encrypted WhatsApp chats.

• Philippines (2026): NBI reported a fraudulent operation using fake Viber, Facebook and Instagram identities; digital forensics linked the Viber accounts to seized devices.

• Philippines (2025): government agencies warned about fake Viber accounts impersonating officials, including GSIS and the National Food Authority.

• Philippines (2025): PSA warned of WhatsApp phishing impersonating the National ID system and asking people to access links, share screens, delete apps, or disable security features.

• Philippines (2024): SEC published an advisory concerning fake accounts using the SEC Chairperson's name on Viber and other messaging apps.

Sources used for this expanded catalogue

• Singapore Police Force — investment scams involving WhatsApp chat groups (4 Jun 2026).

• Singapore Police Force — compromised WhatsApp account impersonation scams (8 May 2026).

• Singapore Police Force — WhatsApp phishing impersonating SingPost (27 Mar 2026).

• Singapore Police Force — WhatsApp senior-executive impersonation (26 Feb 2026).

• Singapore Police Force — WhatsApp compromised accounts used for youth-exchange impersonation (28 Sep 2026).

• Singapore Police Force — job scams involving messaging platforms (29 Aug 2025) and task/survey/affiliate variants (20 Feb 2024; 24 Nov 2025).

• Scamwatch Australia — investment scams hiding in WhatsApp groups (28 Sep 2026); job recruitment scams (20 May 2026); relationship/social-media scams (2026).

• Philippine National Bureau of Investigation — fake Viber/Facebook/Instagram identities and online fraud (31 Jul 2026).

• Philippine Statistics Authority — WhatsApp National ID phishing advisory (5 Jun 2025).

• Philippine SEC — fake accounts using the SEC Chairperson's name on Viber and other messaging apps (23 Sep 2024).

• GSIS / Philippine Information Agency — fake GSIS Customer Service Viber account (3 Jan 2025).

• National Food Authority / Philippine News Agency — Viber impersonation of the NFA Administrator (30 Apr 2025).

Important: The 67 entries are a taxonomy, not a count of distinct criminal schemes or a prevalence ranking. Many variants overlap—for example, a romance scam can become an investment scam, and an account takeover can be used to run an impersonation scam. The same scam can appear on WhatsApp, Viber, Telegram, LINE, SMS, social media, or email.